mentors. Only when he was threatened with dire consequences did he admit his involvement. He also dug out a few weapons wrapped in a polythene sheet that he had buried in a forested area near his village. He was handed over to the police and convicted for his criminal activities. His neutralization was a big blow to the activities of the terrorists in the Lachhipura sector. Fourteen years later, during a visit to Uri as the army chief, I met Fatta Sheikh. 'Abhi bhi badmaashi karte ho?' (Are you continuing your misdeeds), I asked. 'Nahin Jenab' (No sir), was his reply. I gave him a shabash, a pat on the back, alongwith a gift.

In my tenure of two years as the brigade commander of 79 Mountain Brigade, we conducted between 150–200 operations, both big and small, and got good results. We helped the locals make a jeepable road upto Lachhipura from the Uri highway. During this period we lost only five soldiers, whereas we killed over 130 terrorists and apprehended 870. Around seventy-five terrorists surrendered with their AK-47s. Overall, we had recovered 565 weapons and a large number of rockets, grenades and many thousand rounds of ammunition. We did our best to ensure that no innocent was harmed. It was an act of faith for us. Our iron fist was only for the foreign mercenary terrorists and hardcore militants who spread 'dahshat', or terror, amongst the populace. My brigade received seventy-one decorations during this tenure, including one Kirti Chakra, one Shaurya Chakra, eight Sena Medals and over sixty commendations of the chief of army staff and the army commander. Our brigade and the 68 Mountain Brigade were undoubtedly the top achievers of Northern Command during 1991–92, when insurgency in J&K was at its peak. Four battalions that served under me in the brigade, namely, 17 J&K Rifles, 2/11 GR (SHINGO), 15 Punjab (Patiala) and 7 Rajputana Rifles, were awarded unit citations by the chief of army staff for their outstanding contribution to peace in the valley during this period. In addition, 15 Punjab had the unique distinction of also being awarded the unit appreciation of the GOC-in-C Northern Command – the only unit to get both.